

158 Barnabas

The "son of consolation" who saw the best in people and helped them grow.

His given name was Joses, a form of Joseph, but the apostles called him Barnabas, "the son of consolation." It fit him. He first appears selling land and giving the money to the church. When everyone in Jerusalem was afraid of Saul, Barnabas took him to the apostles and vouched for him. When Gentiles began to believe in Antioch, Barnabas was sent to check, and he rejoiced at what he saw. Then he went to Tarsus to find Saul and bring him into the work. Together they carried famine relief to Jerusalem and made the first great missionary journey. Later they parted over John Mark, and Barnabas chose to give the young man a second chance. Acts calls him "a good man, and full of the Holy Ghost and of faith."

At a glance

Name	Joses (Joseph); surnamed Barnabas, "The son of consolation" (Acts 4:36)
Family	A Levite; relative of John Mark ("sister's son," KJV; "cousin" in many translations) (Colossians 4:10)
Home	Cyprus; later Jerusalem and Antioch
When	Active c. AD 30s–50s
Key places	Jerusalem; Antioch; Cyprus; Iconium; Lystra; Derbe
Key people	Paul; John Mark; Peter; James, brother of Jesus; Silas
Main passages	Acts 4:36–37; 9:26–27; 11:19–30; 13–15
Called	An apostle, together with Paul (Acts 14:14)

*"For he was a good man, and full of the Holy Ghost and of faith:
and much people was added unto the Lord."*

Acts 11:24, KJV

The life of Barnabas

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts gives the order but few years; the Claudius famine is usually dated c. AD 44–48.

c. AD 30–33 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Gives his land Josés, a Levite from Cyprus, sells land and lays the money at the apostles' feet. They call him Barnabas. <i>Acts 4:36–37</i>
c. AD 36–38 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Vouches for Saul The disciples fear Saul, but Barnabas brings him to the apostles and tells how he preached boldly in Damascus. <i>Acts 9:26–28; Galatians 1:18</i>
Early AD 40s <i>Antioch</i>	● Encourages new believers Sent to check on Greek believers, he sees God's grace, is glad, and urges them to cleave to the Lord. <i>Acts 11:19–24</i>
Early AD 40s <i>Tarsus and Antioch</i>	● Brings Saul He fetches Saul from Tarsus. They teach a whole year, and the disciples are first called Christians. <i>Acts 11:25–26</i>
c. AD 44–46 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Carries famine relief He and Saul take Antioch's gift to Judea and return with John Mark. <i>Acts 11:27–30; 12:25</i>
c. AD 46–49 <i>Galatia and Jerusalem</i>	● Journey and council He preaches with Saul in Cyprus and Galatia, then defends the Gentiles at the Jerusalem council. <i>Acts 13:1–15:35; Galatians 2:1–10</i>
c. AD 49 <i>Antioch</i>	● Parts from Paul After a sharp disagreement over John Mark, Barnabas takes Mark and sails to Cyprus. <i>Acts 15:36–39</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Galatians 2:11–13 tells of a time at Antioch when Barnabas was drawn away from eating with Gentile believers. Scholars debate whether this happened before or after the Jerusalem council.

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- I Gave generously.** "Having land, sold it, and brought the money, and laid it at the apostles' feet." *Acts 4:37*

 - 2 Stood up for Saul.** "But Barnabas took him, and brought him to the apostles." *Acts 9:27*

 - 3 Rejoiced at God's grace.** In Antioch he "had seen the grace of God, was glad, and exhorted them all." *Acts 11:23*

 - 4 Brought others into the work.** He went to Tarsus to find Saul and brought him to Antioch to teach. *Acts 11:25–26*

 - 5 Carried help to the poor.** He and Saul took the Antioch church's gift to the elders in Judea. *Acts 11:29–30*

 - 6 Answered God's call.** The Holy Ghost said, "Separate me Barnabas and Saul," and the church sent them out. *Acts 13:1–4*

 - 7 Preached in Cyprus and Galatia.** He shared in the first journey, including the meeting with the governor Sergius Paulus. *Acts 13:4–12; 14:1–7*

 - 8 Refused worship.** At Lystra the crowd called him Jupiter and Paul Mercurius. He tore his clothes and cried out that they were only men. *Acts 14:11–15*

 - 9 Defended the Gentiles.** At the council he and Paul told what God had done among the Gentiles. *Acts 15:2, 12*

 - 10 Stumbled at Antioch.** Paul writes that "Barnabas also was carried away with their dissimulation." *Galatians 2:13*

 - II Gave Mark a second chance.** He parted from Paul rather than leave Mark behind. *Acts 15:37–39*

 - 12 Worked for his own living.** Paul names him as one who, like himself, worked rather than rely on the churches' support. *1 Corinthians 9:6*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. His martyrdom at Salamis is tradition only.

Old Testament

Numbers 18:20–24	Levites had no tribal land, yet Barnabas owned some
Isaiah 49:6	"A light of the Gentiles," quoted at Antioch (Acts 13:47)
Echo: 1 Samuel 20	Jonathan stands up for David

New Testament

Acts 4:36–37; 9:27; 11:22–30; 13–15	The main account
Galatians 2:1, 9, 13	Fellowship in Jerusalem; carried away at Antioch
1 Corinthians 9:6	He worked for his own living
Colossians 4:10; 2 Timothy 4:11	Mark, his relative, proves profitable
Tradition	The Epistle of Barnabas and Hebrews are not securely his

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does Acts describe Barnabas in Acts 4:36 and 11:24?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Barnabas trusted people others doubted?
3. *Apply:* Who needs someone to stand beside them, as Barnabas stood by Saul?
4. *Apply:* Is there a disagreement you need to handle with more grace?